

Table of Contents

Table of Contents	3
1. Introduction & Purpose.....	5
How to use this document	5
2. Foundations	6
2.1 Color System.....	6
Brand palette	6
Semantic colors	6
Contrast & accessibility	6
2.2 Typography	7
2.3 Spacing & Grid	7
2.4 Elevation & Shadows.....	7
2.5 Iconography & Imagery.....	8
3. Component Library.....	9
3.1 Buttons	9
3.2 Inputs & Forms	9
3.3 Badges & Tags.....	9
3.4 Data Tables	9
3.5 Cards	10
3.6 Modals & Dialogs	10
3.7 Navigation	10
3.8 Empty, Error & Loading States	10
4. Interaction Patterns & Principles.....	11
4.1 Keyboard Shortcuts (POS)	11
5. Content & Tone	12
5.1 Voice	12
5.2 Formatting Conventions	12
6. Accessibility & Responsiveness.....	13
6.1 Accessibility	13
6.2 Responsive Behavior	13
7. Reference & Governance	14
7.1 Inspiration References	14
7.2 Source Files.....	14
7.3 Versioning	14

BMS

Design System

Visual & Interaction Guidelines for the Business Management System

Version 1.0

July 2026

Table of Contents

Table of Contents	3
1. Introduction & Purpose.....	5
How to use this document	5
2. Foundations	6
2.1 Color System.....	6
Brand palette	6
Semantic colors	6
Contrast & accessibility	6
2.2 Typography	7
2.3 Spacing & Grid	7
2.4 Elevation & Shadows.....	7
2.5 Iconography & Imagery	8
3. Component Library.....	9
3.1 Buttons	9
3.2 Inputs & Forms	9
3.3 Badges & Tags.....	9
3.4 Data Tables	9
3.5 Cards	10
3.6 Modals & Dialogs	10
3.7 Navigation	10
3.8 Empty, Error & Loading States	10
4. Interaction Patterns & Principles.....	11
4.1 Keyboard Shortcuts (POS)	11
5. Content & Tone	12
5.1 Voice	12
5.2 Formatting Conventions	12
6. Accessibility & Responsiveness.....	13
6.1 Accessibility	13
6.2 Responsive Behavior	13
7. Reference & Governance	14
7.1 Inspiration References	14
7.2 Source Files.....	14
7.3 Versioning	14

1. Introduction & Purpose

This document is the single source of truth for visual and interaction design decisions across the BMS (Business Management System) platform. It exists to keep design and development consistent as new screens are added, to prevent re-litigating decisions already made during Stitch iteration, and to give any contributor — designer, developer, or reviewer — a shared vocabulary.

BMS is a multi-tenant retail management SaaS platform built for Kenyan SMEs (supermarkets, shops, and similar retail businesses). It supports organizations, businesses, branches, employees, and role-based access control across owner and cashier roles. The interface must work responsively across desktop, tablet, and mobile, with particular attention to point-of-sale (POS) usability on tablet-class devices.

How to use this document

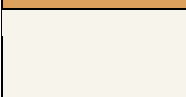
- Foundations (Section 2) rarely change — treat them as tokens, not suggestions.
- Component Library (Section 3) documents reusable UI pieces and their states.
- Interaction Patterns (Section 4) captures hard-won product decisions so they are not re-debated per screen.
- Sections 3-6 are living — update them as new Stitch passes produce new patterns; bump the version history in Section 7 when you do.

2. Foundations

2.1 Color System

The palette is warm, flat, and enterprise-appropriate, referencing Shopify Admin, Linear, and QuickBooks. It avoids gradients, heavy skeuomorphism, and saturated color as decoration — color is reserved for meaning.

Brand palette

Swatch	Token	Usage	Hex
	Primary	Primary actions, active nav, headings, key brand moments	#344E41
	Secondary	Supporting UI, secondary buttons, tag backgrounds	#A3B18A
	Accent	Highlights, promotional callouts, sparing emphasis	#DDA15E
	Background	App canvas / page background	#F7F4EC
	Surface	Cards, panels, modals, table rows	#FFFFFF

Semantic colors

Semantic tokens map to system feedback and must never be substituted with brand colors, even if the hue is close. This keeps meaning unambiguous for owners scanning a dashboard quickly.

Token	Usage	Hex
Success	Completed sales, positive stock, confirmations	#3F7D52
Warning	Low stock, pending approval, near-expiry	#B5842A
Error	Failed payment, validation errors, destructive actions	#AA3B3B
Info	Neutral system messages, tips, informational banners	#3A6EA5

Contrast & accessibility

- Body text on background or surface must meet at least WCAG AA (4.5:1) contrast.
- Accent (#DDA15E) is not used for body text on white or background — it fails contrast; reserve it for large text, icons, or fills with dark text on top.
- Never convey status by color alone — pair semantic color with an icon or label.

2.2 Typography

A single type family keeps the interface calm and legible across dense data screens (POS, tables) and lighter marketing-style pages (Settings, onboarding).

Style	Size / Line height	Weight	Usage
H1	28px / 36px	Bold	Page titles
H2	22px / 30px	Bold	Section headers
H3	18px / 26px	Semibold	Card / panel headers
Body	14px / 22px	Regular	Default UI text
Body Small	13px / 20px	Regular	Secondary text, helper text
Caption	12px / 16px	Regular	Timestamps, metadata, table footnotes
Numeric / Tabular	14-20px / tabular-nums	Semibold	Prices, totals, quantities — always tabular figures

Dense data views (POS cart, inventory tables) may drop one step in the type scale relative to marketing-style pages (Settings, onboarding) to fit more rows without harming legibility — never below Body Small for actionable text.

2.3 Spacing & Grid

- Base spacing unit: 4px. Standard increments: 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32, 48, 64.
- Corner radius: 12px on cards, modals, and primary containers; 8px on inputs and buttons; 999px (pill) on tags and status badges.
- Grid: 12-column grid on desktop ($\geq 1200\text{px}$), 8-column on tablet (768-1199px), 4-column single-stack on mobile ($< 768\text{px}$).
- Gutters: 24px desktop, 16px tablet, 12px mobile.
- Content max-width: 1280px on wide desktop screens, centered, to avoid overly long line lengths on dashboards.

2.4 Elevation & Shadows

The aesthetic is flat, so elevation is used sparingly and only to communicate layering (something is floating above the page), never for pure decoration.

Level	Token	Shadow	Usage
0	flat	none, 1px border only	Cards resting on the page
1	raised	0 1px 2px rgba(0,0,0,0.06)	Hover state on cards/rows

Level	Token	Shadow	Usage
2	overlay	0 8px 24px rgba(0,0,0,0.12)	Dropdowns, popovers, command palette
3	modal	0 16px 40px rgba(0,0,0,0.18)	Modals, dialogs

2.5 Iconography & Imagery

- Icon style: line icons, 1.5px stroke, 20px or 24px frame, matching Linear's restrained density.
- Icons paired with semantic color always carry a text label as well — never icon-only for status.
- Product imagery uses the 12px radius and a subtle 1px border on white backgrounds; missing images fall back to a neutral placeholder tile, never a broken-image icon.

3. Component Library

Every component below should be documented with its full state set before it ships: default, hover, active/pressed, focus, disabled, error, and loading, as applicable.

3.1 Buttons

Variant	Background	Text	Usage
Primary	Primary (#344E41)	White	One per view — the single most important action
Secondary	White, 1px border	Primary	Alternative actions alongside a primary button
Tertiary / Ghost	Transparent	Primary	Low-emphasis actions, inline actions in tables
Destructive	Error (#AA3B3B)	White	Irreversible or data-loss actions, always with confirmation
Disabled	Muted grey	Muted grey	Action unavailable — never hide, always show why on hover

- Minimum tap target: 40px height on desktop, 44px on tablet/mobile (POS terminals are frequently tablets).
- Loading state replaces label with a spinner and disables the button; never allow a double-submit.

3.2 Inputs & Forms

- Default height 40px desktop / 44px tablet; 8px corner radius; 1px border in light grey, primary-colored border on focus.
- Error state: error-colored border plus inline helper text below the field, never a tooltip only.
- Numeric quantity fields (POS cart) are type-only — no plus/minus steppers — per established product decision.
- Required fields are marked with a subtle asterisk, not by color alone.

3.3 Badges & Tags

- Pill shape (999px radius), semantic background at 12% opacity with full-opacity text of the same hue for legibility.
- Used for order/payment status, stock status (in stock / low stock / out of stock), and role labels (Owner / Cashier).

3.4 Data Tables

Data tables are core to a retail system — inventory, sales history, employee lists — and need to hold up at high density without feeling cramped.

- Row height: 48px default ("comfortable"), with an optional 40px "compact" density toggle for power users.
- Sticky header row on scroll; sortable columns show a directional caret only on the active sort.
- Zebra striping is avoided in favor of a subtle 1px row divider, consistent with the flat aesthetic.
- Pagination over infinite scroll for anything a cashier or owner might need to reference precisely (e.g. reconciling a day's sales).

3.5 Cards

- White surface, 12px radius, 1px light border, Level 0 elevation at rest, Level 1 on hover if interactive.
- Dashboard summary cards lead with the number (large, tabular figures), then a label, then a trend indicator using semantic color.

3.6 Modals & Dialogs

- Confirmation dialogs are required for all destructive or irreversible actions (deleting a product, voiding a sale, removing an employee).
- Modal max-width 480px for confirmations, up to 720px for multi-field forms; always dismissible via Escape key and an explicit close control — the escape hatch principle applies everywhere, not just modals.

3.7 Navigation

- Owner: persistent left sidebar with sections for Dashboard, Sales, Inventory, Employees, Reports, Settings.
- Cashier: no sidebar — the POS workspace is a dedicated, cart-dominant, cashier-exclusive layout; owners do not use the POS workspace.
- Tabs (e.g. the 4-tab Profile layout: Profile, Security, Preferences, Activity) use an underline indicator in Primary, not a filled pill, to stay lightweight.

3.8 Empty, Error & Loading States

403, 404, and 500 states are fully designed and should reuse this single pattern rather than being redesigned per occurrence:

- An illustrative icon or simple graphic (never a stock photo)
- A one-line, plain-language explanation of what happened
- A single clear primary action (Go back, Retry, Contact support)
- Empty states (no products yet, no sales today) follow the same shape but replace the explanation with guidance on how to populate the view.

4. Interaction Patterns & Principles

These are product decisions already made through iterative design work. They are documented here so they are applied consistently and not re-argued screen by screen.

Principle	Decision	Rationale
Role-based data scoping	Owner and cashier see different data and navigation, not just different permissions on the same view	Reduces cognitive load; cashiers only need what's relevant to a transaction
POS is cashier-exclusive	Owners do not use the POS Cashier Workspace	Keeps the workspace optimized purely for transaction speed
VAT visibility	VAT is shown on the receipt screen, not during cart-building	Keeps the cart-building view fast and uncluttered; VAT is a KRA-compliance concern surfaced at the point it matters
Quantity editing	Type-only numeric input in POS cart, no plus/minus steppers	Faster for experienced cashiers; steppers slow down high-volume entry
Cashier lockout	Terminal-level PIN model rather than per-cashier session timeout	Matches how shared retail terminals are actually used in practice
Escape hatches	Every flow (modal, multi-step form, wizard) has a clear, obvious way to back out	Prevents users from feeling trapped mid-task
Semantic color usage	Color always maps to meaning (success/warning/error/info), never decoration	Keeps fast visual scanning reliable for owners reviewing dashboards

4.1 Keyboard Shortcuts (POS)

POS shortcuts exist to speed up experienced cashiers without being required for basic use. Document each shortcut here as it's finalized, alongside the screen it applies to.

5. Content & Tone

5.1 Voice

- Plain, direct, and calm — never cute or jokey, since this is operational software people rely on daily for their livelihood.
- Errors state what happened and what to do next, without blaming the user ("Payment couldn't be confirmed — try again or use a different method", not "You entered an invalid amount").
- Confirmations are specific: "3 items removed from cart" rather than "Done."

5.2 Formatting Conventions

- Currency: KES formatted with thousands separators, e.g. KES 12,450.00; M-Pesa references use the standard "M-Pesa" capitalization.
- Dates: DD Mon YYYY for display (e.g. 22 Jul 2026); relative time ("2 hours ago") in activity logs and notifications.
- Numbers in tables are right-aligned and tabular for scannability; text is left-aligned.

6. Accessibility & Responsiveness

6.1 Accessibility

- Minimum tap target 44x44px on touch surfaces (POS tablets, mobile).
- All interactive elements reachable and operable via keyboard; visible focus ring in Primary color.
- Body text maintains WCAG AA contrast on its background at minimum.
- Status is never communicated by color alone — always pair with icon or text label.

6.2 Responsive Behavior

Breakpoint	Range	Layout behavior
Desktop	≥ 1200px	Full sidebar navigation; multi-column dashboards; cart-dominant POS layout with side panel for payment
Tablet	768-1199px	Collapsible sidebar (icon-only by default); dashboard cards reflow to 2 columns; POS remains cart-dominant, primary target device for cashiers
Mobile	< 768px	Sidebar becomes a bottom nav or drawer; single-column stacked layout; POS is not optimized for mobile — owner-facing views (dashboard, reports) are the priority here

7. Reference & Governance

7.1 Inspiration References

Reference	What BMS borrows from it
Shopify Admin	Overall retail-operations information architecture and card-based dashboard layout
Linear	Density, restraint in iconography, keyboard-first interaction model
QuickBooks	Presentation of financial data, tabular figures, and report layouts

7.2 Source Files

- High-fidelity screens are produced in Stitch AI, iterated in focused passes per screen or module.
- Record the Stitch project link(s) and any exported Figma files here once finalized.

7.3 Versioning

Version	Date	Changes
1.0	July 2026	Initial design system document: foundations, component library, interaction patterns, content, accessibility

Update this table whenever a new Stitch pass introduces a new pattern, or an existing decision changes. Keep the change description specific enough that a reader can tell what actually shipped differently.